Afghanistan, Ronald E. Neumann, the Taliban's resurgence was attributed to the 'four years that the Taliban has had to reorganise and think about their approach in a sanctuary beyond the reach of either government'.[44]

The Iraq war had distracted Western political attention and shifted military resources to such an extent that little hope existed for a rerun of the initial successes of Operation Enduring Freedom by the time the US revisited Afghanistan in 2008–09. While the coalition forces ensured that the Taliban remained militarily contained, it had lost the appetite to obviate the possibility of the Taliban's return in totality (as India wanted). The US drone strike campaign in Pakistan's tribal areas (from where the Afghan Taliban operated), which began in 2004, was limited in its ambition. Only ten strikes were executed in a span of four years (2004–07) killing 116 people, of whom 101 were civilians.[45] Despite Narayanan's excellent rapport with the US, India found it difficult to convince Washington (and the UN), as to how difficult the situation on the ground was in its view. This is indicative in a meeting of the India-US counter-terrorism (CT) joint working group on 2 March 2007. From the Indian side, K. C. Singh, assistant secretary on the MEA's CT desk, and Sharad Kumar, joint secretary at the CT desk of R&AW, participated in the meeting, whereas David Mulford, the US ambassador to India, and Frank Urbancic, acting coordinator for CT, represented the US. Presenting a bleak picture of Afghanistan's ground situation, Kumar assessed that the Taliban insurgency was gaining strength, the Kabul government was weak and divided (unable to expand its influence outside of Kabul), and Pakistan was not sincere about uprooting 'terrorist infrastructure' on its soil. Kumar flatly told Urbancic that India knew that Mullah Omar was 'under Pakistani protection'.[46]

Differences between NATO and ISAF over how to deal with the Taliban attacks and their unwillingness to engage in direct combat 'was the wrong approach for the current situation in Afghanistan' according to India. Occurring long before the Indian embassy came under attack in 2008, this India-US Counter-terrorism Joint Working Group (CT JWG) meeting also reflected India's reservations about talking to the Taliban. In a move to pacify the insurgency, the coalition forces had launched political drives to reconcile local and regional political differences in different provinces. The various PRTs were